

STORM KING'S THUNDER

Dubbo Table - Session 0 Packet

Saturday 25 April 2026 - 1:00 pm - local games store in Dubbo

Players	Rules promise	Campaign tone
Josh as Alphie J. Roane	Strict 2014 D&D 5e core rules	Serious but not grim
Talia as Wren	DM makes rulings; players control PCs	M-rated, camera pulled back
Ben as Dorrin Stonebrook	No source-material deviations	Wonder, danger, travel, giants

A practical, spoiler-safe reference for what was agreed, who the characters are, where the campaign opens, and what the table needs to remember before Session 1.

1. Table Snapshot

Purpose of this packet

This PDF collects the Session 0 decisions, table expectations, player and character details, opening-fiction setup, soft-opening travel montage, and reminders for Session 1. It is written for players, not as a DM-only campaign guide, so it avoids hidden spoilers and secret plot material.

Campaign	Storm King's Thunder - Dungeons & Dragons 5e, 2014 rules framework.
DM	Claude running the DM role through the table persona Marcus. DM decisions only; players retain control of their own characters.
Table style	Strict rules, honest consequences, no fudging to save characters, no adversarial DMing.
Campaign start	Level 1. Chapter 1 is expected to move the party to level 2 quickly, then level 3 by the end of the opening arc.
Party	Alphie J. Roane - human wizard; Wren - half-elf bard; Dorrin Stonebrook - hill dwarf Life cleric.
Venue	Local games store in Dubbo, NSW. Table available Saturdays 1:00-4:30 pm unless the owner gives notice for shop events.
Session length	Weekly Saturdays, 1:00-4:00 pm play target, with pack-up by 4:30 pm.
Real-world date	Saturday 25 April 2026, ANZAC Day. Shop opened at 1:00 pm.
Group chat	WhatsApp group created: Storm King's Dubbo. Use mainly for scheduling and lateness; send lore/downtime questions directly to the DM.

Session 0 covered six main areas: campaign and tone, table expectations and safety, strict house-rule/rules-handling approach, character ties, scheduling, and questions before the opening scene.

2. Real-World Opening Scene

The table opened in a grounded, real-feeling Dubbo games-store scene before moving into the campaign world.

Detail	What was established
Time and place	1:00 pm, Saturday 25 April 2026. A cool autumn afternoon, with ANZAC flags still up around Macquarie Street after the morning service.
Store door	Scuffed aluminium-framed glass door; boot marks near the lower section; posters and flyers layered on the glass, including Magic, Warhammer 40K, Pokemon League, and the Storm King's Thunder signup sheet.
Store interior	Long narrow shop, concrete floor, fluorescent tubes, smell of cardboard, plastic sleeves and old paperbacks. Glass cases of singles at the front, painted minis under spotlights, board-game wall, and two trestle tables down the back.
Table setup	Printed DM screen, pencils, campaign book weighted by a dice bag, folded battle mat, dice trays, chairs ready, blank Session 0 checklist on a clipboard.
DM persona	Marcus: late thirties, sandy beard, glasses pushed up, worn hoodie, black canvas folio, relaxed but organised.
Advertisement	Posted online three weeks earlier: 'STORM KING'S THUNDER - D&D 5e. Saturdays 1pm. Three spots. Some experience preferred.'

3. Player Roster

Player	Character	Player experience and table presence	Notes
Josh	Alphie J. Roane - human wizard	Arrived with a clean point-buy character sheet, snacks, and a preference for strict 5e rules, clear expectations, serious fantasy, and no hidden rule-bending.	Alphie's player. Brought the party's primary arcane control and divination-themed scholar energy.
Talia	Wren - half-elf bard	Has played some D&D before: a Curse of Strahd campaign that ended around level 4, plus a homebrew one-shot. Still feels like a beginner and wants the table to work.	Carries a leather dice bag, printed sheet, tabbed spiral notebook, and fidget cube. Plays a lute despite joking about bard stereotypes.
Ben	Dorrin Stonebrook - hill dwarf cleric	Played one short campaign previously as a rogue who died in session 3. Keen but rusty; expects to ask rules questions.	Arrived slightly late due to roadworks past Geurie, with backpack and takeaway coffee. Provides the party's healing and heavier armour.
Marcus / Claude	Dungeon Master	Strict but fair. Runs published material, makes rules calls quickly, and checks player safety/tone clearly.	Keeps the campaign book, DM screen, clipboard, folio, and notebook. Uses spoiler-light campaign pitch for players.

4. Table Agreements and Safety

Core table promise

The game is strict 2014 5e core rules only. The DM can say no when a proposed action, build choice, or interpretation does not follow the rules or campaign source material. Players control their own characters. The DM controls the world, NPCs, monsters, consequences, pacing, and rulings.

Area	Agreement
Tone	M-rated, serious but not grim. Danger, death, loss, travel hardship, giants, frontier peril, and wonder are all expected.
Camera limits	No graphic torture. No sexual content on-screen; romance, if any, fades to black. No harm to children on-screen. Body horror is avoided because Talia flagged squeamishness.
Safety tool	Anyone can say 'pause'. The table stops immediately, no questions and no need to explain. This is the one safety tool Marcus insists on.
PvP	No PvP violence. Character disagreements are roleplayed, not resolved by attacking each other. PC romance is only allowed if both players opt in; it will never be pushed by the DM.
Phones	Phones down unless urgent or needed for the game.
Food and drink	Food and drink are fine. No alcohol in the store.
Snacks joke-rule	Three warnings, then the offender brings snacks. Everyone accepted this in good humour.

5. Rules Handling

Topic	How it works at this table
Rules lookup limit	If a rule is not obvious within about two minutes, the DM makes a call, notes it, checks between sessions, and uses the correct rule going forward. Reversible if needed.
Levelling	Milestone levelling. The opening chapter should move the party off level 1 quickly, with level 3 expected by the end of the opening arc.
Encumbrance	Not tracked religiously. The DM only calls it when carrying capacity becomes obviously silly or fictionally important, such as trying to haul a giant's armour.
Spell components	Costly or consumed components matter. Find Familiar's 10 gp materials matter. Mundane non-cost components are not itemised every time.
Character absence	Default: absent PCs fade into the background. The DM does not roleplay them or make big decisions for them.

Topic	How it works at this table
Absence in dangerous scenes	If it would be strange for an absent PC to vanish mid-dungeon, the DM may have them act defensively with basic actions only and no spell slots burned.
Other players controlling your PC	Default is no. A player can explicitly opt in for that session, such as letting someone handle a simple shopping scene.
Dice and death	The DM will not fudge dice to save characters, but will not go out of the way to kill them. The world responds honestly.

6. Venue and Practical Logistics

Owner	Dave, the shop owner, has cleared the regular RPG table. He is described as an ex-teacher who bought the shop after retiring.
Shop conditions	Buy something occasionally, pack up by 4:30 pm sharp if a 5:00 pm event is scheduled, and keep the table respectful and not rowdy.
Table booking	Every Saturday 1:00-4:30 pm unless Dave needs the space for a tournament or event.
Notice	Dave will try to provide two weeks' notice if the table needs to move.
Backup	If the table is unavailable: skip a week or move online for one session.
Sickness plan	Online if one person is crook and still able to play; cancel if two are out; run with two if one is out.
Commitment	Three-month commitment through the end of July 2026, then review.

7. Campaign Pitch - Spoiler-Safe

What players know

Storm King's Thunder is set in the Forgotten Realms, in the rugged northern region known as the Savage Frontier. The roads are long, weather matters, frontier towns are vulnerable, old ruins dot the landscape, and something vast has gone wrong among the giants.

Element	Player-facing summary
Region	The Savage Frontier: the North of Faerun. Frontier towns, wilderness, hard roads, old magic, and settlements separated by real danger.
Core premise	An ancient giant hierarchy called the Ordning has been broken. Giants of many kinds are moving in ways ordinary folk do not understand.
Giant types named in pitch	Hill, stone, frost, fire, cloud, and storm giants.
Threat	Towns are being attacked, travel is more dangerous, and something has gone wrong at a level far above most mortals.
Heroic starting point	The PCs are not chosen ones. They begin as low-level adventurers who happen to be in the wrong place at the right time.
Likely campaign length	Roughly level 1 to around level 11 or 12 at this table, likely a year or more of weekly sessions if played through.
Tone	Serious but not grim. Wonder and danger both matter: flying castles, ancient magic, enormous giants, loss, and growth.

The DM's expectation is that the characters will probably grow up over the course of the campaign. The North is a hard place, and the campaign does not pretend otherwise, but it is not meant to be misery for misery's sake.

8. Starting Location - Nightstone

Feature	Description known to the players
Settlement	Nightstone, a small frontier town on the High Road in the North.
Nearby city	Roughly a day's travel from Daggerford.
Population	About 130 people, mostly farmers and hands.
Main features	Inn, smithy, temple, tavern, manor house, village square, and the standing stone that gives the town its name.
The Nightstone	A tall, dark, weathered stone in the square, said by locals to be older than the town.
Road role	Nightstone is the last waypoint before the road gets properly wild.

Soft-opening choice

The table chose to use the remaining Session 0 time for a soft opening: no combat, no dice unless asked, just roleplay and scene-setting as the characters approach or arrive in Nightstone.

9. Session 0 Scene Chronology

- Josh enters the Dubbo games store at 1:00 pm after the shop opens on ANZAC Day.
- Marcus greets Josh, checks Alphie's sheet, and confirms the point-buy math, standard human adjustments, saves, AC, HP, spellbook size, and prepared spell count.
- Marcus allows Giant as Alphie's noble-background language because it fits scholarly Roane-library flavour, but warns it will not solve every giant-related problem.
- Find Familiar is approved. Alphie may pre-buy the 10 gp materials. The ritual will occur during first proper downtime; the raven familiar will be named Ink.
- Talia arrives with Wren, the half-elf bard planned for College of Lore. She takes snacks and introduces herself as somewhat experienced but still beginner-feeling.
- Ben arrives late due to roadworks near Geurie. He introduces Dorrin Stonebrook, hill dwarf Life cleric of Berronar Truesilver.
- Marcus notes the party has a good shape: wizard, bard, cleric - arcane, charisma, divine - though the front line is thin apart from Dorrin's armour and shield.
- The table agrees on tone, safety, scheduling, rule handling, PvP boundaries, group chat, missed-session handling, store rules, and character ties.
- Marcus gives the spoiler-light Storm King's Thunder pitch and establishes Nightstone as the opening location.
- The group creates the WhatsApp chat and chooses the soft opening instead of wrapping early.

10. Character Backgrounds and Player-Facing Notes

These are player-facing summaries based on the Session 0 conversation and the level 1 character sheets. Subclass plans are noted but not activated until the correct level under 2014 5e rules.

Alphie J. Roane - Human Wizard 1	
Player	Josh
Race / class	Human wizard, level 1.
Subclass plan	School of Divination at wizard level 2. Not active at level 1.
Background	Noble.

Family	House Roane, cider traders from the Waterdeep hinterlands.
Personality	Bookish, polite, sheltered in some ways, curious, and slightly too eager to prove he is useful beyond family status.
Campaign reason	Travelling north on Roane family business after a minor cousin or trade contact in Nightstone went quiet. Letters have returned or gone unanswered for weeks.
Rules notes	Point-buy was checked as legal: 8, 14, 13, 15, 10, 12 before standard-human bonuses. Saves are Intelligence and Wisdom. HP 8 at level 1. AC 12, or 15 with Mage Armour.
Language ruling	Giant is allowed as a background language due to noble scholarship and old Roane library texts. It is useful flavour, not a skeleton key.
Familiar	Raven familiar named Ink. Materials may be pre-bought for 10 gp. Ritual occurs in first proper downtime, likely end of session 1 or start of session 2 depending on pacing.
Role in party	Arcane control, ritual utility, scholar, omen-reader, and careful question-asker.

Alphie table reminder

Position of Privilege is flavour and social context, not a magic wand that forces NPCs to obey. It may open doors with appropriate people, but it does not override the fiction, rules, or NPC motives.

Wren - Half-Elf Bard 1

Player	Talia
Race / class	Half-elf bard, level 1.
Subclass plan	College of Lore at bard level 3. Not active at level 1.
Background	Travelling performer. The character plays a lute, while Talia jokes about trying not to be a bard stereotype.
Training	Studied at one of the smaller Waterdhavian colleges, with Lore-college ambitions.
Road life	Has been walking the High Road circuit for about eighteen months, earning coin in villages, inns, and halls where she can.
Campaign reason	Heading to Nightstone because the inn pays a fair rate and the innkeeper, a dwarf called Morak, treats musicians well.
Guarded detail	She does not answer directly when asked where she grew up. Alphie and Dorrin both notice that she gently steers around the question.
Connection to Alphie	Performed at a Roane gathering one season. Alphie was the only one who treated her like a person afterwards rather than merely tipping her, so she remembers him fondly.
Role in party	Face, support caster, social bridge, storyteller, performer, and future Lore-bard skill engine.

Dorrin Stonebrook - Hill Dwarf Cleric 1

Player	Ben
Race / class	Hill dwarf cleric, level 1.
Domain	Life Domain, active from cleric level 1.
Faith	Cleric of Berronar Truesilver, goddess of home, hearth, family, and the dwarf-mother.
Age	Around 140, which is solid middle-age by dwarf reckoning.
Temperament	Quiet, practical, healer first and fighter second. Likely to be the party's steadier presence.
Origin	Served as a temple healer in a small dwarf-hold east of Daggerford.
Campaign reason	Sent north because pilgrims and traders have reported strange stories: abandoned settlements, missing livestock, and one report of something huge on a ridge at dusk.

Connection to Alpie	House Roane tithes to a few northern temples. Dorrin has seen the Roane name on a ledger, so he and Alpie are not close friends, but not complete strangers either.
Role in party	Healer, stabiliser, divine caster, moral centre, and the closest thing to a front line due to heavy armour and shield.

11. Party Relationship Map

Relationship	Established tie	Useful play cue
Alpie and Wren	Wren once performed at a Roane gathering. Alpie treated her with real personhood rather than as hired entertainment.	Wren has a soft spot for Alpie; Alpie may recognise her as someone talented and sharp, not just a performer.
Alpie and Dorrin	Dorrin knows the Roane name from temple ledgers because House Roane supports some northern temples.	They can start with respectful familiarity rather than immediate trust.
Wren and Dorrin	No strong prior tie established before the travel montage, but three hours on the cart begins a tentative warmth.	Wren may test Dorrin with humour; Dorrin may quietly assess whether she is trustworthy.
Whole party	Three friendly travellers share road, food, drink, and early stories before reaching Nightstone.	Trust is beginning but not complete. Good opening dynamic: polite, curious, cautious, and warming.

12. What the Characters Learn During the Cart Ride

Travel montage context

The group skips forward three hours on a cart trail through rising hill country. Sace, the horse, pulls steadily. The land shifts from farmland to scrub to heath. The road is unusually empty for late afternoon, which the DM tells players to file away.

About	What the other PCs learn
Alpie	Younger son of House Roane, cider traders out of the Waterdeep hinterlands. Polite, curious, writes more than he says, and wants to be useful. Travelling because a Roane contact in Nightstone has gone silent. Wizard-in-training with divinatory leanings.
Wren	Half-elven performer trained at a smaller Waterdhavian college. Has worked the High Road circuit for about eighteen months. Performed at Roane manor once. Avoids answering where she grew up. Heading to Nightstone because Morak pays fairly and treats musicians well.
Dorrin	Hill dwarf cleric of Berronar Truesilver, around 140 years old. Temple healer, quiet observer, sent north to investigate strange reports from travellers and pilgrims. Healer first, fighter second.
Shared meal	The travellers share bread, hard cheese, and cider. Sace declines the cider with great dignity. There are a few laughs and the beginning of real warmth.

13. Soft Opening - Road to Nightstone

This section summarises the table's soft-opening fiction. It is useful for remembering atmosphere and continuity when Session 1 begins.

Scene beat	Details
The High Road	Runs north out of Daggerford and bends west toward the coast. The journey is long and exposed, with different travellers moving at different speeds.
Date in the Realms	Second day of Eleint, early autumn. Late afternoon, low golden sun, cold moorland wind, woodsmoke in the air.

Scene beat	Details
Approach	After three hours on the cart trail, the group sees Nightstone valley in the distance, with the bell tower peeking above a rise. They are roughly twenty minutes out.
Travel distance	The cart covers roughly nine miles in three hours due to trail conditions and a long climb that Sace takes at a walk.
Road omen	The road is unusually empty: no wagon, courier, or trader coming out of Nightstone despite the time of day.
Landscape	Gentle uplands south of the Ardeep rather than true mountains: farmland gives way to scrub, then heath. Two farmsteads show chimney smoke; an old shepherd raises a hand from a distance.

14. Nightstone Arrival Atmosphere

Nightstone is introduced as a small frontier settlement in a shallow valley. It has a low stone wall more symbolic than military, a bridge over the river, a guard tower, thatched cottages, temple, smithy, manor, central square, and the named standing stone.

Place	Read-aloud-style memory
Village wall	Low stone wall around the town, more decorative than defensive.
Bridge and river	A wooden bridge crosses the river that loops around the village. The river is narrow this far north.
Guard tower	A bored-looking man-at-arms leans on a halberd and waves travellers through without much question in the earlier scene setup.
Village square	At the centre stands a tall dark stone twice the height of a man, weathered smooth on the windward side.
Nightstone Inn	Three storeys, slate roof, swinging sign with a painted stone, lamps lit in the windows, smell of stew and bread, and stringed music drifting through open shutters.

15. Character Hooks into Nightstone

Character	Why they are going to Nightstone	Possible first-scene energy
Alphie	Roane family business: a cousin or trade contact in Nightstone has gone silent, and his father wants someone to see what has happened.	Polite concern; trying to be useful; watchful for signs of trade disruption or social impropriety.
Wren	Due to perform at Nightstone's inn. Morak the innkeeper pays fairly and treats musicians well.	Comfortable with inns and working rooms; may be first to notice the mood of common folk.
Dorrin	His temple sent him north to quietly investigate reports of abandoned places, missing livestock, and enormous shapes at dusk.	Measured, observant, pastoral; checks whether people are safe before chasing rumours.

16. Open Questions for Session 1

- Does Alphie ask Wren or Dorrin anything specific during the three-hour cart ride before Nightstone?
- Does Wren choose to reveal anything more about where she grew up, or keep steering around it?
- Does Dorrin share any details about his temple, abbot, or the reports that sent him north?
- Who speaks first when the group reaches the village approach?
- Is Ink currently decorative, caged, perched, or not yet fully summoned until the downtime ritual?
- How openly does Alphie present himself as noble when arriving in Nightstone?
- Does the group enter as fellow travellers, cautious allies, or near-strangers sharing convenience?

17. Ink the Raven - Familiar Notes

Form	Raven.
Name	Ink.
Mechanics	As a familiar, Ink is a spirit taking a beast form. It cannot attack. Alphie can perceive through its senses within 100 feet. It can deliver touch spells as allowed by Find Familiar.
Timing	The actual hour-long ritual will happen in first proper downtime, likely end of Session 1 or start of Session 2 depending on pacing.
Cost	10 gp in material components for each casting of Find Familiar.
Risk	Familiars can die, especially if caught in area damage. Re-summoning costs another hour and 10 gp, and the emotional sting is real even though the spell can bring the familiar back.
Vibe	Ink suits a divination wizard: omen-bird, watchful companion, black-feathered note in the margin of Alphie's story.

18. Strict 5e Character-Level Reminders

Character	Important level reminder
Alphie	Wizard level 1 does not yet have School of Divination features. He can be thematically divination-inclined, but Portent and the school feature begin at wizard level 2.
Wren	Bard level 1 does not yet have College of Lore features. Lore is her planned college at bard level 3.
Dorrian	Clerics choose Divine Domain at level 1 under 2014 rules, so Life Domain is active now.
Whole party	Level 1 is fragile. Sleep, healing, positioning, caution, and retreat matter.

19. Session 1 Player Checklist

Bring / remember	Why it matters
Character sheet	Keep the latest PDF or printout handy.
Dice and pencil	The store has supplies, but personal dice/pencil makes play smoother.
Rules patience	The table uses two-minute lookups, then DM ruling and later correction if needed.
Snack or small store purchase	Supports Dave's store and honours the venue agreement.
Your character's opening mood	Decide how Alphie/Wren/Dorrian is feeling twenty minutes out from Nightstone.
One thing to ask another PC	Helps the party feel like people, not just sheets.
Pause tool	Anyone can say 'pause' if content lands wrong.

20. One-Page Quick Reference

Game	Storm King's Thunder, 2014 D&D 5e, strict core rules.
Time	Saturdays, 1:00-4:00 pm play; pack-up by 4:30 pm.
Tone	M-rated, serious but not grim, wonder plus danger.
Safety	Say 'pause' anytime. No explanation required.
No-go / limits	No graphic torture, no on-screen harm to kids, no sexual content beyond fade-to-black, avoid body horror.
Rules disputes	Two-minute check, DM ruling, note it, fix next time if wrong.
Levelling	Milestone. Level 1 should pass quickly.
PvP	No PvP violence. PC romance only with both players opting in.

Group chat	WhatsApp for scheduling and lateness; DM direct for lore/downtime.
Absent PCs	Fade to background unless mid-danger; then defensive basic actions only.
Start	Nightstone, late afternoon, Second of Eleint. The road has been strangely empty.

Best opening posture for the party

Arrive curious but cautious. The road to Nightstone has been too quiet. Alphie has personal/family business, Wren has professional expectations at the inn, and Dorrin has a duty to investigate strange reports. None of them know yet how quickly a simple arrival can become an adventure.